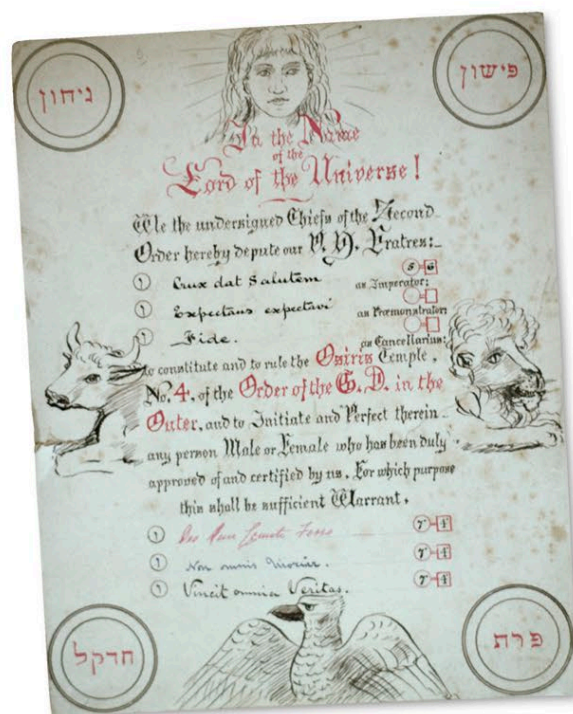


THE HERMETIC ORDER OF THE GOLDEN DAWN

occult science, mystery, and ritual magic



▲ Official charter

Drawn up by Moina Mathers (née Bergson) in December 1888, this charter officially established the Hermetic Order of the Golden Dawn. It was signed by all three founders: Mathers, Westcott, and Woodman.

No spiritual movement encapsulated the late 19th-century Western fascination with the occult, magic, and ritual more precisely than the Hermetic Order of the Golden Dawn. Founded in 1888, it offered a complex, scholarly program of initiation, study, and spiritual growth, yet in its early form it barely lasted 15 years, torn apart by bitter disputes.

Striving for spirituality

The Hermetic Order of the Golden Dawn was established by the Englishmen William Woodman, Samuel Mathers, and William Westcott. All three were Freemasons (see pp.194–197) and immersed in almost every

strand of Western mystery tradition and ancient magic. The aim of the Order was to pull these strands into a coherent form and to achieve new levels of spiritual perception through the disciplined practice of ritual magic. For members, the path to mystical awakening was akin to a form of alchemical purification: base physical matter transmuted into new spiritual gold.

► Ceremonial regalia

Painted here by his wife Moina in the full ceremonial regalia he wore for magic rituals, Mathers was the driving force of the Golden Dawn. However, he was so eccentric that he was expelled from the Order in 1900.

Initiation and ritual

Members hoped to achieve this spiritual awakening partly by invoking angels and archangels, gods and goddesses, and elemental spirits, and partly by taking part in elaborate Egyptian-influenced rituals charged with magical meaning and complete with fantastical costumes, backdrops, and props. This theatrical aspect of the movement was particularly evident in the initiation ceremonies, in which initiates were bound to a cross and made to swear allegiance to the Order, while robed figures performed undisclosed ritual acts around them.

A secretive society, the Order jealously guarded details of its practices, and initiation was by invitation only. A member's journey to a higher spiritual plane involved passing through three spheres of consciousness and growth—a structure that mirrored that of the kabbalistic Tree of Life



“Vestigia Nulla Retrorsum
[Prudence never retraces its steps].”

MOTTO OF **SOROR V.N.R.**, PEN NAME OF MOINA MATHERS (NEE BERGSON)